North Airport Drive Civic Association

Protecting Our Community — The Facts

Highland Springs: A Community Built on Water

Highland Springs takes its name from the **nine natural springs** that once flowed through the area. In 1890, entrepreneur Edmund Sewell Read purchased 200 acres to develop a resort community around these springs, marketing the spring water as having curative properties. The springs fed the same shallow water table aquifer that supplies private wells in the area today — an aquifer that Henrico County describes as **"especially vulnerable to contamination from pollutants on the land around them."**

The Chickahominy River: A State Scenic River

The Chickahominy River is an 87-mile Coastal Plain river designated as a **State Scenic River** by the Virginia General Assembly under Virginia Code § 10.1-410.1. This designation requires state agencies to consider the river's scenic, recreational, historic, and natural values during any planning or permitting process.

The Virginia Department of Conservation and Recreation describes the tidal freshwater vegetation along the Chickahominy as **"the most impressive in the Mid-Atlantic region."** The river feeds Chickahominy Lake, a 1,230-acre reservoir that supplies **drinking water to the City of Newport News**.

In September 2023, the Capital Region Land Conservancy permanently protected **170 acres and 1.5 miles of Chickahominy River frontage** through a conservation easement. Henrico County also designates **Resource Protection Areas (RPAs)** with mandatory **100-foot vegetated buffers** along waterways under the Chesapeake Bay Preservation Act.

Wildlife & Endangered Species

The lower Chickahominy watershed has been recognized as harboring **"some of the most biologically diverse and ecologically significant areas in the Coastal Zone of Virginia"** by the Virginia DCR. Documented species include:

Status	Species
Endangered	Atlantic sturgeon, Sensitive joint-vetch, Peregrine falcon
Threatened	Bald eagle (state), Canebrake rattlesnake, Loggerhead sea turtle
Protected	Bald eagle (federal), Great blue heron rookeries
Rare	American shad, Hickory shad, River herring

PFAS "Forever Chemicals"

Richmond International Airport, located adjacent to the North Airport Drive corridor, is identified as a likely source of PFAS contamination. The Henrico County PFAS Well Sampling Initiative (2022) found the highest PFAS concentrations in surface water **"in close proximity to the Richmond International Airport."**

In May 2025, the Virginia Department of Health issued a **fish consumption advisory for eastern Henrico County** due to elevated PFAS found in fish tissue. PFAS are water-soluble "forever chemicals" that do not break down in the environment and are linked to cancer, thyroid disease, and immune system effects.

Stormwater BMPs: Necessary but Not Sufficient

Developers point to Best Management Practices (BMPs) as proof their projects won't harm water quality. The evidence says otherwise:

- A 2026 UVA/VDOT study found that **many BMPs degrade significantly within years** due to inadequate maintenance
- HOAs often lack the expertise or funding to maintain complex stormwater infrastructure

- A 2025 peer-reviewed study found that **PFAS passes through conventional BMPs largely unfiltered**
- Even properly maintained BMPs cannot remove dissolved contaminants like PFAS, pharmaceuticals, or microplastics

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The Fiscal Reality: Growth Doesn't Pay for Itself

The American Farmland Trust has compiled over 200 Cost of Community Services studies nationwide. The pattern is consistent:

Land Use	Cost per $1.00 of Revenue
Residential	1.05–**1.67**
Farm / Open Space	0.29–**0.37**
Commercial / Industrial	0.27–**0.30**

Virginia communities show similar results: Clarke County found residential land costs $1.26 per$ **1.00** of revenue, while farm/open space costs only **$0.26**.

Traffic & Safety Concerns

Our roads were built for rural traffic — **narrow, two-lane roads with ditch drainage, no sidewalks, and limited sight lines**. A single-family home generates approximately **10 vehicle trips per day** (ITE). A 130-home subdivision would add roughly **1,300 daily vehicle trips** to roads never designed for that volume.

Community Victories

- **REZ-2024-101760 — DENIED:** Dorado Capital proposed 49 homes on 36 acres of North Airport Drive. The Board of Supervisors denied the rezoning, citing incompatibility with the area's rural residential character.
- **REZ-2024-101268 — DENIED:** A proposed 130-home subdivision on N. Washington Street was denied after strong community opposition.

What You Can Do

1. **Join the Association** — Visit nadca-hs.org/get-involved
2. **Attend Board of Supervisors & Planning Commission meetings** — Your voice matters in public hearings
3. **Talk to your neighbors** — Share this fact sheet and spread the word
4. **Contact your Supervisor** — Varina District Supervisor Tyrone E. Nelson: (804) 501-4208

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*All facts on this sheet are sourced from official government documents, Virginia state law, and peer-reviewed scientific reports. Full citations and source links are available at **nadca-hs.org/history**.*

North Airport Drive Civic Association — Highland Springs, Varina District, Henrico County, Virginia